

House Mena

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"THE WEAK SHALL FALL TO THE STRONG"

Quick Facts

Status: Marquess/Marquis

Nickname: The Mena Beasts

Origin: Aicruae (Northern)

Founded: 8,736 BR

Founder: Phiyano Mena

Seat: Atop a mountain in the Town of Paler, Northern Aicruae

Faction: Neutral Faction (shares values of both the Divine Faction and the Common People Faction)

Spirit Animal: Giraffe

Colors: TBD

Wealth: 87,000 Rern (reduced after War of Fera reparations; originally a vast fortune from Cidet reconstruction payment)

Military: 5,000 soldiers on stand-by (on par with House Caraen)

Religion: Rillic (sub-religion; believes humans fuel the gods' strength and give them a tether to the mortal world)

House Name Meaning: Mountain

Theme Song: "Indestructible" by Welshly Arms

Status By Era

Pre-Empire Era: Active. Founded in 8,736 BR by Phiyano Mena after completing reconstruction of the Cidet. Their noble title was granted by the Cidet, not the Imperial Palace.

Solis's Era: Survived. House Mena survived the civil war between Solis and The Twins. Their line continues all the way up until the events of A Princess in Love, when members of House Mena were killed by Merigen Bleelack for failing to swear loyalty to him.

Crandona's Era: Eradicated. Members of House Mena were killed by Merigen Bleelack for failing to swear loyalty to him during his six-year rule.

Minara's Era: [TBD]

Why They Matter

House Mena didn't claw their way to nobility through warfare or inheritance. They built it. Literally. Phiyano Mena, a man born so ugly that people joked his father had slept with a horse, reconstructed the Room of Glory in the Cidet and helped build the Hall of Heroes for the Castle of Aicruae. The Cidet itself granted him his noble title, not the crown. That distinction mattered. It meant House Mena's legitimacy came from religious and architectural achievement, and that relationship gave them something no other house had: exclusive passage to the Cidet whenever they wanted.

But what makes House Mena truly strange in Aicruae's history is the beast. Early members of the house displayed physical traits that clashed with Aicruae's beauty standards so severely that Phiyano was nicknamed "Sand Face" because people said his features shifted like sand in a desert. His granddaughter Sirrah still carried the beast traits, and one of her nine husbands conducted experiments to "cure" her of them. Those experiments killed her. It took generations, but Bartyei Mena eventually became the first member known for his looks rather than in spite of them. The beast disappeared from the bloodline. What replaced it, though, was a family curse of a different kind: brilliance paired with catastrophe.

Fransei Mena proved that at fourteen years old. Born during political unrest, she single-handedly secured her family's position and orchestrated the scheming that triggered the War of Fera. She was so valuable, so essential to the kingdom, that even after the war, House Mena couldn't be directly punished. So Fransei took the fall alone. Hilatoma Dajanyi hanged her, and she died at fourteen, and her family lived because of the work she'd already done.

House Mena is a house that earned everything the hard way and lost it all twice: once through Fransei's execution, and again centuries later, when they were wiped out entirely for refusing to kneel.

Heraldry

The Crest: A lozenge (diamond-shaped) shield on a field of dark charcoal black. At center stands a golden giraffe in profile facing left, spotted in black, tall and upright on all four legs. Seven arrows fly toward the giraffe from multiple directions. Six have wooden shafts with golden arrowheads and purple fletching. One, positioned directly above the giraffe's head, carries blue fletching instead of purple. None of the arrows have struck the animal. The giraffe stands unbothered.

Symbolism:

The giraffe is the strangest spirit animal in Aicruae and that's the point. Every other house picked something fierce. Panthers, hounds, sea serpents. House Mena picked the tallest animal alive. Not the fastest, not the deadliest, not the most beautiful. The tallest. Because Mena means "Mountain," and that's what this family is. Phiyano Mena was born so ugly people said his father slept with a horse. They called him "Sand Face." He rebuilt the Room of Glory in the Cidet and the Hall of Heroes for the Castle of Aicruae, and the Cidet itself gave him a noble title for it. Not the crown. The Cidet. He didn't need to be beautiful or loved. He needed to be useful, and he was so useful they had to make him a lord.

The giraffe carries that same energy. It doesn't look like a predator. It doesn't move like one either. But it stands taller than everything around it. It sees farther. It reaches higher. And if you've ever watched one fight, you know a giraffe can kill a lion with a single kick. The Mena Beasts earned their nickname honestly. Early members of the house carried physical traits that clashed with Aicruaen beauty standards so badly that one of Sirrah Mena's nine husbands ran experiments on her trying to "cure" her of them. Those experiments killed her. The beast in the bloodline was real, and the giraffe on this crest doesn't hide it. It wears its strangeness standing up.

The seven arrows flying at the giraffe and missing tell the story of a family the world kept trying to bring down. House Mena has been shot at from every angle for their entire existence. Phiyano was mocked for his face. Sirrah was experimented on and killed. Fransei was hanged at fourteen. The house lost its fortune paying War of Fera reparations. And in Crandona's Era, they were wiped out entirely by Merigen Bleelack for refusing to swear loyalty. Seven arrows, seven directions, and not one of them hits the giraffe. It isn't dodging. It isn't running. It's standing still. The arrows miss because House Mena doesn't flinch.

The single blue-fletched arrow among six purple ones is different on purpose. Six purple arrows represent the attacks that come from noble society, from the world of status and beauty standards and political scheming that House Mena never fit into cleanly. Purple is devotion and noble spirit, the same purple from the Divine Faction's aesthetic. Those are the arrows shot by people who think they're above the Menas. The blue arrow is something else. It comes from above, straight down. Blue is loyalty. That arrow is the one the Menas never saw coming. The betrayal by someone they trusted. The Cidet that gave them their title but couldn't protect Fransei. The crown that let a fourteen-year-old girl hang for a war she started to save her family. The blue arrow is the one that should have killed them. It still missed.

The dark charcoal black field is grief, constancy, and the mountain itself. Mena means "Mountain" and this family lives on top of one, literally, in the Town of Paler in Northern Aicruae. Black is the color of something that absorbs everything. Every blow, every humiliation, every generation of being called beasts and monsters and ugly. The black field swallows all of it. The giraffe stands gold against it because House Mena has always been the brightest, strangest thing in the room, and the darkness around them has never been able to put that light out.

The golden color of the giraffe is wealth and divine favor. The Cidet paid House Mena for the reconstruction work, and that payment became their original fortune. Gold is also the color of the Rillic faith, where believers hold that they exist to fuel the gods' strength and give them a tether to the physical world. The giraffe is gold because the Menas believe they were built by the gods for a reason. Not to be pretty. Not to be liked. To be strong. And to last.

House Colors: Black and Gold. Black for the mountain, for grief, for the ability to absorb everything thrown at them. Gold for divine favor, for the wealth they earned by building sacred spaces, and for the belief that strength is its own kind of beauty.

Motto: "The Weak Shall Fall to the Strong." The most brutal motto in Aicruae, and the most honest. House Mena doesn't dress its philosophy up in metaphor or softening language. If you're weak, you fall. If you're strong, you stand. That's it.

Phiyano was strong. They laughed at his face and he built them a Hall of Heroes. Sirrah wasn't strong enough to survive what her husband did to her, and she fell. Fransei was the strongest person in the kingdom at fourteen years old, strong

enough to trigger a war and save her family's position, and they hanged her for it. She fell too. But the house stood. The motto doesn't promise survival for individuals. It promises survival for the family. If you're strong enough, the name continues. If you're not, the name finds someone who is.

The really ugly truth of the motto is that House Mena applies it to themselves as much as anyone else. Sirrah fell because the beast in her blood made her a target and she couldn't escape. Fransei fell because she was fourteen and the world doesn't care how smart you are at fourteen. The Menas in Crandona's Era fell because they refused to bend to Merigen Bleelack, and he killed them for it. "The Weak Shall Fall to the Strong" isn't a threat pointed outward. It's a mirror. The giraffe on the crest is standing because it's the one that didn't fall. Not yet.

Power & Influence

Source of Power

Architectural and religious prestige. House Mena earned their noble title through the reconstruction of the Cidet, and that relationship granted them exclusive passage to the Cidet whenever they pleased (normally the Cidet must invite you). Their wealth originally came from the Cidet reconstruction payment, though it was reduced after War of Fera reparations.

Military Forces

5,000 soldiers on stand-by.

Lands & Income

Seat: Atop a mountain in the Town of Paler, Aicruae (Solis's Era).

Key industries: [TBD]

Alliances & Rivalries

Allied Houses

[TBD]

Rival Houses

[TBD]

Relationship with the Crown

Tense, due to the War of Fera.

Relationship with House Dajanyi

Tense. Tension remains over War of Fera events. Hilatoma Dajanyi executed Fransei Mena.

Marriage Alliances

House Patton (Royal Marriage): Duke Nayiler Mena married Princess Aliedea Cawiloan Patton, daughter of King Haliour Layern Patton I and Queen Walica Kevena Patton.

Connection to House Najil: Distant relatives. Lady Vaseiula Mena married Ser Winsafantero Paneta. Their son Zacareneal Paneta (8,707 BR - 8,705 BR) was the father of Asa Najil/Asa Panetta, the founder of House Najil.

House Culture

Religion

Rillic (sub-religion). Believers hold that they were put on this planet to fuel the gods' strength and give them a stronger tether to the physical/mortal world.

Traditions

[TBD]

Values

[TBD]

Reputation

[TBD]

How Others Perceive Them

[TBD]

History

Founding (8,736 BR)

Phiyano Mena, born in a rural village in Northern Aicruae in the town that would become Paler, earned his noble title after completing the reconstruction of the Cidet. His renovations to the Cidet and his aid constructing the Hero's Hall earned him the title. Notably, his title was granted by the Cidet itself, not the Imperial Palace. As part of this relationship, House Mena was granted exclusive passage to the Cidet whenever they liked, a privilege normally reserved only for those the Cidet formally invites.

Rise to Power

[TBD]

Major Achievements

Construction of the Hall of Heroes for the Castle of Aicruae.

Reconstruction of the Room of Glory in the Cidet, incorporating religious relics and creating some of the greatest architectural works the world has ever seen.

Granted exclusive passage to the Cidet whenever they liked.

Major Disgraces

The War of Fera. Fransei Mena led the scheming that triggered the war and was executed by hanging at age 14 by Hilatoma Dajanyi. However, because Fransei had worked to make House Mena so essential to the kingdom before the war, the house itself could not be directly harmed. Fransei took the punishment alone while her family survived.

Notable Creations

[TBD]

The Mena Beast Trait

A defining and unusual feature of the early house. Phiyano Mena had a "hideous appearance" that contrasted Aicruae beauty standards, earning him the nickname "Sand Face" because people believed his face moved in every direction

like sand in a desert. Rumors claimed his father Huiarge had intercourse with a horse (most likely false, but used to explain his appearance). His granddaughter Sirrah and great-grandson Nabeyano were the last known members to display traits of the beast. Sirrah's husband Mauzepe conducted research and experiments to cure her physical traits, but the experiments ended with Sirrah's death. Bartyei Mena, Sirrah's son, is credited as the reason House Mena no longer resembles a beast. The family started gaining popularity for their attractive looks beginning with him.

Notable Members

Listed chronologically, from the house's origins through the generations.

Phiyano Mena (8,758 BR - 8,700 BR)

Founder of House Mena

Born in a rural village in Northern Aicruae, in the town that would become Paler. His upbringing was strange due to rumors surrounding his birth. Some claimed his father Huiarge had intercourse with a horse, a story most likely false but used to explain his hideous appearance, which contrasted sharply with Aicruae beauty standards. Nicknamed "Sand Face" because people believed his face moved in every direction like sand in a desert.

Despite these rumors, Phiyano was an accomplished warrior and scholar, considered one of Aicruae's brightest minds. His renovations to the Cidet and his aid constructing the Hero's Hall earned him a noble title, founding House Mena in 8,736 BR. His title was granted by the Cidet, not the Imperial Palace.

Duke Nayiler Mena (8,747 BR - 8,679 BR)

Royal Marriage Alliance

Husband of Princess Aliedea Cawiloan Patton, daughter of King Haliour Layern Patton I and Queen Walica Kevena Patton. Nayiler was given the temporary title of Duke specifically so he could marry the princess. Father of twin daughters Lady Naern Mena and Lady Vaseiula Mena.

Vamedeus Der Mena (8,732 BR - 8,698 BR)

House Champion

Phiyano's prized nephew and half-cousin/first husband of Sirrah Mena. Set to become the next head of House Mena, but died during a tragic hunting incident at age 34. He left behind two sons, Bartyei and Nabeyano, and a grieving wife.

Before his death, he requested to sing to his wife. In Aicruae, singing is held in a romantic and loving light. It is an indication of love because it is believed to have started life itself. His wife Sirrah grieved for a decade before remarrying multiple times.

Lady Naern Mena (8,716 BR - 8,660 BR)

Twin Daughter of Princess Aliedea and Duke Nayiler Mena

Married Count Jinegi Liazen. Their daughter, Lady Isalian Liazen, became Queen Isalian Liazen, wife of King Haliour Layern Patton II.

Lady Vaseiula Mena (8,716 BR - 8,692 BR)

Twin Daughter of Princess Aliedea and Duke Nayiler Mena

Married Ser Winsafantero Paneta. Their son Zacareneal Paneta (8,707 BR - 8,705 BR) was the father of Asa Najil/Asa Panetta, founder of House Najil.

Sirrah Mena

Second Daughter and Heir of Phiyano Mena | Wife of Vamedeus Der Mena

One of the last known members to display traits of the beast. Had nine husbands over her lifetime. Her first husband was Vamedeus Der Mena, her half-cousin. One of her later husbands, Mauzepe, carried out research and experiments to cure her physical traits. The experiments ended with Sirrah's death, leaving House Mena in mourning.

Bartyei Mena (8,703 BR - 8,625 BR)

Older Son of Vamedeus and Sirrah | Father of Fransei

The reason House Mena no longer resembles a beast. Starting with Bartyei, the family began gaining popularity for their attractive looks. But despite his appearance, Bartyei was "extremely dumb (only good for swinging a sword)" and caused House Mena to fall into turmoil. His inability to run the Mena territory

caused a shockwave in high society for decades, so severe that his fourteen-year-old child was the only one who could fix it, at the cost of her own life.

Nabeyano Mena

Son of Vamedeus and Sirrah

One of the last known members to display traits of the beast.

Inarala Mena (8,672 BR - 8,597 BR)

"The Little Beast of Mena"

First great-granddaughter of Phiyano Mena, born to his eldest daughter's line. The first woman in Aicruae's history to receive the name "Gafer," a term for a woman who doesn't marry, essentially a shrew. Known for her nasty temper, which scared men, earning her the additional nickname "Paer Ga" (a wicked woman with a slick tongue).

Said to have been so rude that thousands of noblemen petitioned King Hailour Layern Patton II to remove her tongue. The king refused and laughed them off because his wife, Queen Isalian, was best friends with her.

Fransei Mena (8,669 BR - 8,655 BR)

The War of Fera

Born during a time of political unrest, the young Lady Fransei of Mena worked hard to secure her family's position due to her father's negligence. Despite her age, she sought to equip her family with suitable advisors and took a large part in the scheming that led to the War of Fera.

Executed by hanging at age 14 by Hilatoma Dajanyi, known as "Aicruae's great hero" who prevented Aicruae and Coelum from falling to the Mena family. But because Fransei had worked to make her family so essential to the kingdom before the war, House Mena could not be directly harmed for the family's role in the conflict. Fransei took the punishment herself while her family survived. Despite her behavior, House Mena was not harmed. Fransei was a genius, revered and respected even by her enemies and the king.

Hilatoma personally carried out the punishment and execution of all War of Fera participants. Fransei and Hilatoma are often compared to each other. Fransei was

a genius unparalleled in brains, so much so that even her enemies would fight her as they would fight anyone else. She was revered and respected even by the king despite her age for her brilliance.

Queen Yaseira Neacei Patton (7,340 BR - 7,268 BR)

Queen from House Mena

From House Mena; married King Jesuin Walica Patton. Described as “anything but weak,” Yaseira was a skilled hunter and horsewoman who reportedly outshot her husband at their wedding tournament. Their marriage was passionate but volatile, full of legendary arguments and equally legendary reconciliations. She bore four children, though only Darien (the future King Darien Lacern Patton) survived to adulthood.

Strengths & Weaknesses

Known For

[TBD]

What They Lack

[TBD]

Vulnerabilities

[TBD]

Role in Narrative

Book Appearances: A Princess in Love (House Mena is eradicated during this book’s events, killed by Morgant for failing to swear loyalty).

Plot Significance: [TBD]

Key Members in Story: [TBD]

Cross-References

House Patton, House Dajanyi, House Najil, House Caraen, King Haliour Layern Patton I, Queen Walica Kevena Patton, King Haliour Layern Patton II, Queen Isalian

Liazen, King Jesuin Walica Patton, King Darien Lacern Patton, Princess Aliedea Cawiloan Patton, Hilatoma Dajanyi, Morgant, Merigen Bleelack, Ser Winsafantero Paneta, Asa Najil/Asa Panetta, Count Jinegi Liazen, Northern Aicruae, Town of Paler, The Cidet, Castle of Aicruae, Hall of Heroes, Room of Glory, War of Fera, Rillic (Religion), Neutral Faction, A Princess in Love (Book 3)

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